

What happens when a routine laboratory observation makes you curious?

During my day-to-day laboratory work, I started noticing what appeared to be an increase in VDRL testing and positive results.

That observation made me ask:

Could this be a signal worth monitoring?

Syphilis/VDRL Test Positivity Rate

Indicator Definition & Monitoring Playbook

Portfolio Demonstration Project

 **Laboratory observation** →  **Curiosity** →  **Monitoring**

I didn't want to jump to a conclusion.

Recent 2026 research on syphilis in Nairobi caught my attention and made the question even more interesting.

Instead of asking:

✗ “Is syphilis increasing?”

I asked:

“How would we systematically monitor this signal?”

Then came the questions:

What indicator should we use?

What belongs in the numerator?

What belongs in the denominator?

What data would we need?

How do we know whether the data are reliable?

The referenced study is a medRxiv preprint and is not presented as evidence of a national increase.

 **Laboratory observation** →  **Curiosity** →  **Monitoring**

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The indicator

Syphilis/VDRL Test Positivity Rate

Positive valid tests

_____ × 100

Total valid tests

Unit: Percentage (%)

Recommended aggregation: Monthly

Measures the proportion of valid reported syphilis/VDRL tests that are positive during a defined reporting period.

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What does the data need to tell us?

An indicator is only as good as the data behind it.

CORE DATA



Test date



Test type



Test result



FACILITY



County



Age



Sex



Pregnancy status



Service point



ANC/PNC

Data quality matters.

Completeness • Validity • Uniqueness • Consistency • Timeliness



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The Lesson

A rise in positivity ≠ proof of a rise in disease burden.

Before interpreting an increase, ask:

Did testing volume change?

Did the population being tested change?

Did reporting practices change?

Are there missing or duplicate records?

Are repeat tests influencing the numbers?

Is the pattern consistent across facilities or locations?

Then:

A signal should trigger investigation—not premature conclusions.

 **Laboratory observation** →  **Curiosity** →  **Monitoring**

My interpretation framework

OBSERVE



VALIDATE



COMPARE



INVESTIGATE



INTERPRET



ACT

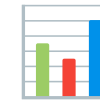
A structured approach helps distinguish a genuine epidemiological signal from changes caused by testing patterns, reporting or data-quality issues.

 Laboratory observation →  Curiosity →  Monitoring

From a laboratory observation to a monitoring framework.

The playbook brings together:

 Laboratory Science

 Healthcare Data

 Monitoring & Evaluation

 Data Quality

What's inside?

- ✓ Indicator definition
- ✓ Measurement rules
- ✓ Data requirements
- ✓ Data sources & flow
- ✓ Data-quality checks
 - ✓ Disaggregation
 - ✓ Interpretation
- ✓ Reporting & visualization
 - ✓ Troubleshooting
 - ✓ Worked example

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